TALK ONE

# 1 The Anointed One

*"He first findeth his own brother Simon, and saith unto him, We have found the Messias, which is, being interpreted, the Christ."*

JOHN 1:41

Andrew had spent one day with Jesus. Afterward, he went to find his brother Simon and told him, "We have found the Messias, which is, being interpreted, the Christ." I wonder what Simon thought when he heard that. People had been waiting for the Messiah for generations, and now his brother was saying he had found Him. John kept that word, Messias, in his account and then translated it for his Greek readers. Messiah and Christ mean the same thing: anointed. We say "Jesus Christ" so often that we may not stop to think about what we are calling Him. What does it mean that Jesus is the Anointed One?

In ancient Israel, a person was anointed by having oil poured on his head to set him apart for an office. When Aaron and his sons were anointed as priests, the oil they used was holy. The Lord had given Moses instructions for making it with myrrh, cinnamon, other spices, and olive oil. He also warned that anyone who made it for another purpose or poured it on an outsider was to be cut off from the people. This was something sacred. Aaron and his sons were being given a responsibility to serve the Lord, and the anointing marked them as God's.

The same idea appears in the accounts of kings and prophets. When Samuel found David among his brothers, David was still a shepherd boy. Samuel "took the horn of oil, and anointed him in the midst of his brethren: and the Spirit of the Lord came upon David from that day forward." The Lord also told Elijah to anoint Elisha "to be prophet in thy room," or to take his place as a prophet. Priests, kings, and prophets had different responsibilities, but each was anointed with that holy oil by someone with authority to do the Lord's work. David took that seriously even when it was difficult. When he later had a chance to kill Saul in a cave, he refused because Saul was "the

Lord's anointed." Saul had been trying to kill him, but David still believed Saul was the Lord's to deal with.

All of that history was behind the word Andrew used. The English word Messiah appears only in the book of Daniel, where an angel tells Daniel about "Messiah the Prince," who would come and then be "cut off." But the Hebrew word behind it is also the word used for an anointed priest or king. By the time Jesus came, people were waiting for the Anointed One, though they disagreed about what He would look like and what he would do.

Jesus's connection to kingship went back through His family. When Jacob blessed his sons, he said of Judah, "The sceptre shall not depart from Judah..." King David came from the line of Judah, and the kings of Judah came from David's family. Matthew opens his Gospel by calling Jesus "the son of David" and then traces Mary's husband Joseph's genealogy through those kings. By the time Jesus was born, no king from David's line had ruled for centuries. Herod was called a king because Rome had made him one, but the people knew he was not David's heir. Jesus, through the house of Joseph, was David's heir by birth.

But in ancient Israel, being from Judah raises a question about the priesthood. The priests in the temple were descendants of Levi, and Jesus was not from that tribe. The book of Hebrews says, "our Lord sprang out of Juda; of which tribe Moses spake nothing concerning priesthood." Jesus never served at the altar in Herod's temple, and under the law of Moses He could not have. Yet the same scripture calls Him a priest "after the order of Melchisedec." Melchizedek was the priest who blessed Abraham long before Levi was born. That priesthood is older and greater than Aaron's, and in the Restoration the Lord calls it the Holy Priesthood, after the Order of the Son of God. It is His own priesthood. The priests serving in Jerusalem held an office that pointed to Him.

A prophet speaks for God, and Jesus described His teaching this way: "the Father which sent me, he gave me a commandment, what I should say, and what I should speak." He spoke what His Father gave Him to say. So we find all three anointed offices in Jesus: king, priest, and prophet. Under the law of Moses, a king could not serve as a priest, and the priests were not kings. In Jesus, those offices came together. We begin to see why He is called the

Anointed One when we understand He had been anointed to all three of Israel's most holy offices.

But who anointed Him? Samuel poured oil on David in front of his brothers. We do not read about anyone doing that to Jesus to make Him king or priest. Two women anointed Him with ointment as acts of love, and He said one of them had done it for His burial, but neither was an anointing into office. Peter gave the answer when he said, "God anointed Jesus of Nazareth with the Holy Ghost and with power." The Father anointed Him, with the Holy Ghost instead of oil. The scriptures do not tell us exactly where and when that happened. Our understanding of the pre-existence includes that He was chosen and set apart before the world was formed. We do, though, have an account of Jesus telling people that He had been anointed—and what He had been anointed to do.

Luke wrote that Jesus returned to Nazareth, where He had grown up, and went to the synagogue on the Sabbath as He usually did. He stood to read, and someone handed Him the book of Isaiah. He found this passage: "The Spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he hath anointed me to preach the gospel to the poor; he hath sent me to heal the brokenhearted, to preach deliverance to the captives, and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty them that are bruised, To preach the acceptable year of the Lord." Then He closed the book, handed it back, and sat down. Everyone was watching Him. He said, "This day is this scripture fulfilled in your ears."

These people had known Jesus growing up. Now He was telling them that these words from Isaiah were about Him. He was anointed to help the poor, the brokenhearted, the captives, the blind, and the bruised. These are people with needs they cannot meet on their own.

A Samaritan woman at a well also heard Jesus say who He was. She told Him, "I know that Messias cometh, which is called Christ." He answered, "I that speak unto thee am he." She was speaking about someone she expected to come in the future, and He told her He was there, talking with her. In both stories, Jesus spoke to the kinds of people He had been anointed to help.

John, who recorded Andrew's words, later wrote that Christ "hath made us kings and priests unto God and his Father." Jesus intends to share an anointing with us. When we qualify to receive the ordinances of the temple, we also will be anointed. All bearers of the Holy Priesthood who magnify their calling will qualify to be anointed as saviors on Mount Zion--called to help the Lord save God's children.

Andrew did not know all of this when he went to find Simon. He had spent a day with Jesus, and he wanted his brother to meet Him. We have more of the story than Andrew had that day. We can read what Jesus said in Nazareth and what He told the woman at the well. We can learn about His priesthood and His kingship and the work His Father sent Him to do. As I think about these things, I also think about what it means for me to call Jesus the Messiah.

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*The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.*